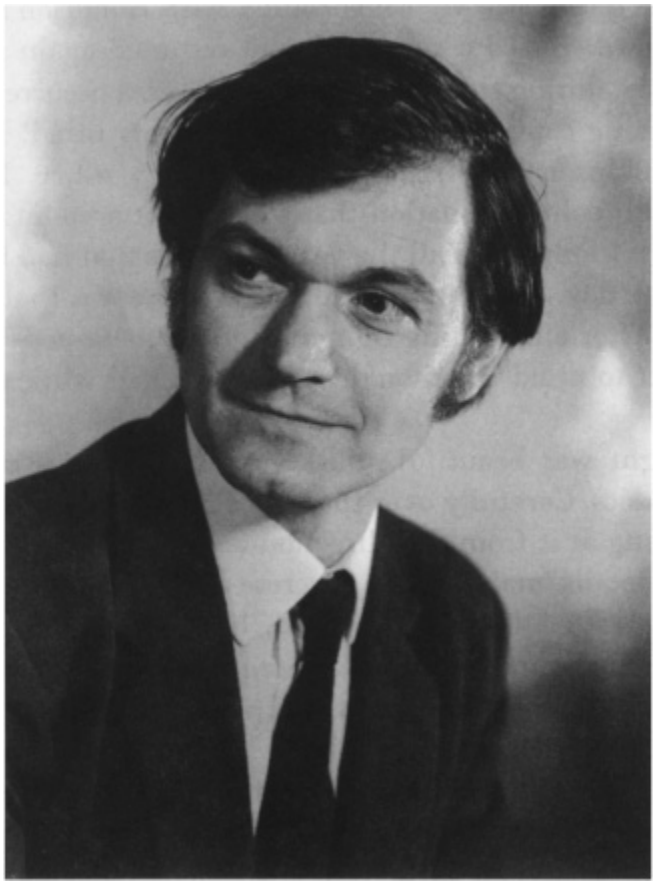
Thereupon Dennis Sciama began with Roger Penrose the pattern he would continue with his own students in the 1960s (Stephen Hawking, George Ellis, Brandon Carter, Martin Rees, and others; see Chapter 7). He pulled Penrose into long discussions, sessions of many hours' length, about the exciting things happening in physics. Sciama knew everything that was going on; he infused Penrose with his enthusiasm, with the excitement of it all. Soon Penrose was hooked. He would complete his Ph.D. in mathematics, but the quest to understand the Universe henceforth would drive him forward. He would spend the coming decades with one foot firmly planted in mathematics, the other in physics.



Roger Penrose, ca. 1964. [Photo by Godfrey Argent for the National Portrait Gallery of Britain and the Royal Society of London; courtesy Godfrey Argent.]

New ideas often arrive at the oddest moments, at moments when one is least expecting them. I suppose this is because they come from one's subconscious mind, and the subconscious performs most effectively when